

STANDARD OPERATING PROCEDURE

DETAILED QA CALIBRATION & ROOT CAUSE ANALYSIS

Evaluation Calibration • AOS • AOI • RCA • Findings & Coaching

Document Control	Details
Document Owner	Quality Assurance / Operations
Process	QA Evaluation Calibration and Performance Improvement
Version	1.0
Status	Portfolio / Demonstration SOP
Primary Outputs	Calibrated score • AOS/AOI • RCA • Findings & Coaching • Action Plan

1. Purpose

This SOP provides a detailed, repeatable method for calibrating QA evaluations and converting evaluation results into actionable performance insights. It covers independent scoring, evaluator alignment, identification of Areas of Strength (AOS) and Areas of Improvement (AOI), Root Cause Analysis (RCA), and the development of Findings & Coaching (F&C). The objective is to move beyond a score and identify what happened, why it happened, what should change, and how improvement will be verified.

2. Scope

This process may be used for customer service, technical support, back-office, sales, or other monitored interactions where a defined QA scorecard is used. It applies to QA Analysts, QA Leads, Team Leaders, Operations Leaders, Trainers, and SMEs involved in quality evaluation, calibration, coaching, or process improvement.

3. Definitions

Term	Definition
QA Evaluation	A structured assessment of an interaction against approved quality criteria and scoring standards.
Calibration	A controlled review in which evaluators independently score the same interaction and align on the correct interpretation of the scorecard.
AOS - Area of Strength	A demonstrated behavior or process step performed correctly and consistently, supported by observable evidence.
AOI - Area of Improvement	A specific behavior, process step, or knowledge gap where performance did not meet the expected standard.
RCA - Root Cause Analysis	A structured method for determining the underlying reason a performance gap occurred instead of addressing only the visible symptom.
F&C - Findings & Coaching	A documented summary of the evaluation finding, evidence, impact, expected behavior, coaching provided, and agreed action.
Critical Error	A defined failure with material customer, compliance, security, financial, or business impact, according to the applicable scorecard/policy.
Calibration Variance	The difference between independent evaluator scores before alignment.

4. Roles and Responsibilities

Role	Responsibilities
QA Analyst	Evaluate independently; document evidence; identify AOS/AOI; participate in calibration; complete accurate records.
QA Lead / Manager	Facilitate calibration; resolve scoring differences; maintain standards; monitor recurring variance and quality trends.
Team Leader / Operations	Provide operational context; validate coaching actions; support accountability and follow-up.
Trainer / SME	Clarify policy, product, process, or knowledge questions and support corrective learning.
Agent / Employee	Review applicable feedback, confirm understanding, complete agreed actions, and demonstrate improvement.

5. Required Materials and Data

- Current approved QA scorecard and scoring definitions.
- Current policies, SOPs, knowledge articles, or process maps applicable to the interaction.
- Selected interaction/case and required system records.
- Independent evaluator scorecards completed before the calibration discussion.
- Previous coaching or calibration records when recurrence is being investigated.
- Relevant customer feedback, NPS/RSAT/RFT results, or operational metrics when they are part of the approved analysis.

6. End-to-End Process Overview

Phase	Key Question	Output
1. Prepare	Are the sample, scorecard, and standards current?	Calibration-ready case
2. Evaluate	What does the evidence show?	Independent scores and evidence
3. Compare	Where do evaluators disagree?	Variance list
4. Calibrate	Which score is supported by the standard?	Final calibrated evaluation
5. Identify AOS/AOI	What was done well and what missed the standard?	AOS/AOI statements
6. Conduct RCA	Why did the AOI occur?	Root cause and contributing factors
7. Create F&C	What feedback and action should follow?	Findings & Coaching record
8. Follow Up	Did the action change behavior/results?	Validation and closure

7. Step 1 — Prepare the Calibration

- Confirm the scorecard version and effective date.
- Confirm the interaction is eligible for calibration and that required evidence is available.
- Select a representative sample based on the approved sampling method.
- Identify all evaluators who will participate.
- Provide the same source material to all evaluators; do not disclose another evaluator's score before independent scoring.
- Define the calibration objective, such as score consistency, a new scorecard item, recurring variance, or a critical behavior.

8. Step 2 — Conduct Independent Evaluation

Each evaluator should score the interaction independently before the group discussion. Evaluators should:

- Review the entire interaction before finalizing the score where the process requires it.
- Use observable evidence from the interaction rather than assumptions.

- Apply the exact scorecard definition and applicable policy.
- Record concise evidence for any missed or failed item.
- Flag potential critical errors separately when applicable.
- Identify preliminary AOS and AOI observations.
- Avoid changing a score simply to match another evaluator.

9. Step 3 — Compare Evaluations and Identify Variance

After independent scoring, compare the evaluations item by item. Focus discussion on material differences rather than defending a personal scoring preference.

Variance Type	Example	Calibration Approach
Interpretation variance	Evaluators read the same behavior differently.	Return to the scorecard definition and observable evidence.
Policy variance	Evaluators used different policy versions or interpretations.	Confirm the current approved requirement and document clarification.
Evidence variance	One evaluator identified evidence the other missed.	Review the source interaction/system record together.
Scoring application variance	Same evidence but different points assigned.	Apply the approved scoring rule consistently.
Scope variance	Evaluators included/excluded a behavior from the item.	Confirm item scope and evaluation instructions.

10. Step 4 — Conduct the Calibration Discussion

- Start with the scorecard item and the evidence—not the evaluator's personality or experience.
- Ask each evaluator to state the score and the evidence supporting it.
- Review the exact scorecard language.
- Check the relevant policy/process documentation when needed.
- Distinguish between an actual performance failure and a documentation or system issue.
- Agree on the final score only after the evidence and standard are reviewed.
- Document unresolved questions and assign an owner for clarification.
- Communicate any scoring interpretation that should be applied in future evaluations.

11. Step 5 — Identify Areas of Strength (AOS)

An AOS should be specific, evidence-based, and behavior-focused. Avoid generic statements such as 'good call' or 'excellent service.' Identify what the agent did, why it was effective, and what should be repeated.

AOS Component	Required Detail	Example
Behavior	What was done well?	Confirmed the customer's concern before proposing a solution.
Evidence	Where was it demonstrated?	Agent summarized the issue and verified understanding.
Impact	Why did it matter?	Reduced ambiguity and created a clear path to resolution.
Replication	What should continue?	Continue using confirmation and recap techniques on similar contacts.

12. Step 6 — Identify Areas of Improvement (AOI)

An AOI should identify a specific gap against an expected standard. It should be written so the agent can understand exactly what needs to change.

AOI Component	Required Detail	Example
Gap	What was not met?	Required verification was not

		completed before account information was discussed.
Standard	What should have happened?	Complete the approved verification sequence before proceeding.
Evidence	What proves the gap?	The interaction moved to account details before verification was completed.
Impact	Why does it matter?	Creates avoidable compliance and customer-risk exposure.
Expected behavior	What should happen next time?	Follow the verification sequence every time the applicable trigger is present.

13. Step 7 — Determine Whether RCA Is Required

RCA is appropriate when the gap is recurring, material, unexplained, systemic, or unlikely to be solved by a simple reminder. Consider RCA when:

- The same AOI appears across multiple evaluations.
- The same agent repeats the same error after coaching.
- Multiple agents demonstrate the same failure.
- The process, policy, system, or knowledge base may be contributing to the gap.
- A high-impact or critical error occurs.
- Performance data shows a meaningful decline or recurring pattern.

14. Step 8 — Conduct Root Cause Analysis (RCA)

Use a structured sequence. The objective is to identify the controllable root cause without stopping at the symptom.

RCA Step	Question	Example Output
1. Define the problem	What exactly happened?	Verification step missed on applicable contacts.
2. Establish evidence	How often, where, and under what conditions?	Appeared in 4 of 12 sampled evaluations.
3. Ask why	Why was the expected action not completed?	Agent moved directly to resolution after identifying the issue.
4. Continue probing	What enabled that behavior?	Verification trigger was not consistently recognized.
5. Check contributing factors	What else may be involved?	Knowledge article wording and workflow prompts may be unclear.
6. Identify root cause	What underlying condition best explains the gap?	Inconsistent understanding of the verification trigger.
7. Validate	Does the cause fit the evidence?	Review additional samples and compare with training/process guidance.
8. Define action	What will prevent recurrence?	Targeted refresher, job aid clarification, and follow-up sampling.

15. RCA Categories

Category	Typical Root Cause Indicators	Possible Corrective Action
People / Knowledge	Agent does not know, recall, or understand the requirement.	Targeted coaching, refresher training, knowledge check.
Process	Workflow is unclear, inefficient, or inconsistently followed.	Process clarification, checklist, workflow redesign.
Policy	Requirement is unclear, conflicting, or recently changed.	Policy clarification and communication.
System / Tool	System behavior or access creates an execution barrier.	System fix, configuration change, workaround, escalation.
Documentation	SOP/job aid is missing, outdated, or difficult to use.	Update documentation and communicate revision.
Communication	Expectation was not clearly communicated.	Leader/QA communication and standardization.

Work Environment	Time, staffing, workload, or operational conditions contribute.	Operational review and workload/process adjustment.
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16. Step 9 — Findings & Coaching (F&C)

F&C should connect the evaluation result to an actionable coaching conversation. A strong F&C record is factual, specific, behavior-based, and measurable.

F&C Field	What to Document
Finding	Specific scorecard gap or strength identified.
Evidence	Observable facts from the interaction/case.
Customer / Business Impact	Effect on customer experience, compliance, efficiency, quality, or risk.
Expected Standard	Approved behavior, process, or policy requirement.
Root Cause	Validated reason for the gap, when RCA is required.
Coaching Message	Clear explanation of what to continue, stop, or start doing.
Action	Specific improvement activity agreed with the agent/team.
Support Required	Training, job aid, SME support, system/process help, or clarification.
Success Measure	How improvement will be measured.
Follow-Up	Owner, review date, and validation method.

17. Recommended F&C Conversation Structure

1. Set the context: Explain the purpose of the coaching and review the interaction objectively.
2. Reinforce AOS: Recognize the behavior that should continue.
3. Present AOI: Describe the specific gap and show the evidence.
4. Explain impact: Connect the behavior to customer, quality, compliance, or business impact.
5. Ask for self-assessment: Allow the agent to explain what happened and identify barriers.
6. Share the standard: Clarify the expected behavior using the approved reference.
7. Address root cause: Confirm whether the gap is knowledge, process, policy, system, or another cause.
8. Agree on action: Define one or more specific actions with measurable expectations.
9. Confirm understanding: Ask the agent to summarize the expected behavior.
10. Set follow-up: Define when and how improvement will be validated.

18. Sample F&C Record

Field	Sample Entry
Finding	Required verification step was missed before account details were discussed.
AOS	Agent demonstrated strong ownership by clearly summarizing the customer's issue and confirming the requested resolution.
AOI	Verification sequence needs to be consistently completed when the applicable trigger is present.
Evidence	Review of the interaction showed account information was discussed before the required verification step.
Impact	Potential compliance exposure and increased customer-risk handling.
RCA	Agent understood the general verification requirement but did not consistently recognize the trigger in this scenario.
Coaching	Reviewed the verification trigger and walked through the correct sequence using the approved procedure.
Action	Complete targeted refresher and apply the verification checklist on applicable contacts.
Success Measure	No repeat occurrence across the next agreed monitoring sample.
Follow-Up	QA/Team Leader to review subsequent evaluations and confirm sustained compliance.

19. Calibration Decision Rules

- Use the approved scorecard as the primary authority.
- Do not average conflicting scores simply to create a middle score.
- The final score should reflect the evidence and the approved scoring rule.
- Document the reason for any changed score.
- Escalate unclear standards rather than creating an undocumented interpretation.
- Separate agent performance issues from process/system issues.
- Do not label an agent's personal trait as a root cause when the evidence supports a process, knowledge, or system cause.

20. Trend Analysis and Governance

Calibration should not be treated as a one-time scoring exercise. QA leadership should review recurring AOS, AOI, RCA categories, and F&C actions to determine whether a problem is isolated or systemic.

Trend	Question to Ask	Management Response
Repeated AOI	Is the same behavior failing repeatedly?	Targeted coaching or training.
Multiple-agent AOI	Are several agents experiencing the same gap?	Investigate process, policy, documentation, or training.
Recurring calibration variance	Are evaluators interpreting an item differently?	Clarify scorecard language and recalibrate.
High critical-error frequency	Is there material risk?	Escalate and prioritize corrective action.
AOS pattern	What behaviors are consistently producing strong outcomes?	Share best practices and reinforce them.

21. QA Calibration Documentation Checklist

Checkpoint	Complete
Current scorecard/version confirmed	☐
Sample and source evidence confirmed	☐
Independent evaluations completed	☐
Variance identified and discussed	☐
Final score and rationale documented	☐
AOS documented with evidence	☐
AOI documented against the standard	☐
RCA completed when required	☐
F&C documented	☐
Action owner and due date assigned	☐
Follow-up/validation method defined	☐
Recurring trends escalated where appropriate	☐

22. Expected Outputs

- A consistent and defensible final QA evaluation.
- Clear AOS statements that reinforce effective behaviors.
- Specific AOI statements that define improvement requirements.
- Validated root causes rather than symptom-based explanations.
- Documented Findings & Coaching linked to evidence and standards.
- Measurable follow-up actions and accountability.
- Trend insights that can support training, process improvement, and operational decisions.

23. Document Control

This SOP should be reviewed whenever the QA scorecard, evaluation methodology, policy, process, product, or calibration governance changes. Version history should be maintained to preserve traceability.